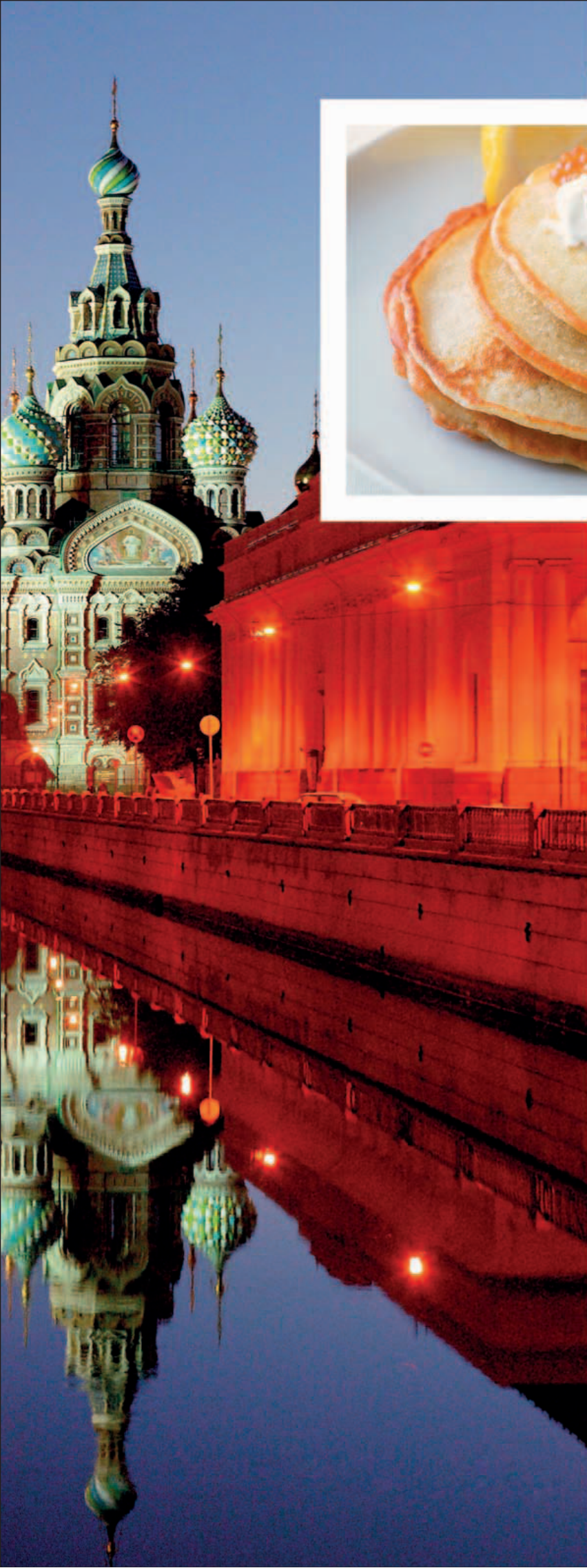




Above Mounds of caviar with sour cream and a sprig of dill constitutes the classic blini topping

Left The Church of the Resurrection of Christ, also known as the “Church of the Savior on the Spilled Blood,” was built in 1883 in the style of 16th- and 17th-century Russian churches



Above Once the food of poor villagers living by the Caspian Sea, caviar became the choice of the elite before becoming widely available across Russia

Zakuski

On restaurant menus, blinis with caviar (or mushrooms or puréed herring) come under the heading of *zakuski*, or hors d'oeuvres. Salted sprat or herring, gherkins, pickled garlic, spiced feta, cold meats, gelatins, and salads are also popular, together with the oddly named *selyodka pod-shuby* – herring “in a fur coat” of beet, carrot, egg, and mayonnaise. *Zakuski* form the basis of the *Russky stol*, or “Russian table,” which among the Czarist upper classes was merely the prelude to the main meal of the day. The *Russky stol* can be enjoyed at restaurants or private parties celebrating New Year, Orthodox Christmas (January 6–7), or “Old New Year” (January 13–14).

The Best Places to Eat Blinis

Caviar Bar & Restaurant

expensive

If money's no object, reserve a table at the Caviar Bar & Restaurant in the Grand Hotel Europe, where Tchaikovsky spent his honeymoon. Founded in the 1870s, the Yevropeyskaya (as locals call the hotel) became an orphanage after the 1920s Civil War and was only restored to its previous splendor six decades later. Though there's no formal dress code, you'll feel underdressed in casual wear amid the Caviar Bar's Art Nouveau marble decor, damask upholstery, and tinkling fountain.

Its menu offers such delights as Kamchatka crab, Siberian *pelmeni* (ravioli) in Champagne sauce, sturgeon and salmon mousse – and blinis with caviar. Their blinis are cooked to perfection – thin and crispy – and the caviar is mouthwatering, from the finest Beluga and Sterlet to unsalted (*malossol*) red caviar (which elsewhere tends to be over-salted). Served with panache, they are best washed down with shots of ice-cold vodka, of which there's a vast range of different flavored brands available.

Mikhailovskaya ul. 1–7, St. Petersburg; open 5 PM–midnight daily; www.grandhoteleurope.com

Also in St. Petersburg

You needn't spend a fortune to enjoy blinis with caviar. Provided they're freshly made, they can be delicious in cafés or as carry-outs from street kiosks serving Russian-style fast food. Some chains serve deep-frozen blinis, defrosted in a microwave, which are truly revolting. If in doubt ask, “*Oni svyezhi?*” (“Are they fresh?”). One sure-fire option – that also offers an all-you-can-eat *zakuski* buffet – is **Yolki Palki** (*inexpensive*), a rustic-style chain of Russian tavernas with 24-hour branches at Malaya Konyushennaya 9 and Nevsky Prospekt 88. Besides a selection of vodkas, they also serve *kvas*, a delicious beverage made from fermented rye bread. Neither branch takes reservations.

Also in Russia

Yolki Palki (see above) is ubiquitous in Moscow, but **Teremok** (www.teremok.ru; *inexpensive*), a chain with kiosks near metro stations, is a good alternative for a carry-out. For a sit-down meal in Moscow, try the funky **Café Margarita** (www.cafe-margarita.ru; *inexpensive*), named after the heroine of Mikhail Bulgakov's classic novel, *The Master and Margarita*.

Around the World

Blinis are also a feature of Polish, Yiddish, Lithuanian, and Ukrainian cuisine, and feature on the menu in restaurants from Vilnius to Berlin and beyond. In the US, there are many Russian restaurants in Brooklyn; the **Baku Palace** (www.bakupalace.com; *moderate*) also has Azerbaijani dishes on its menu.